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Exploring the Symbolism of Birds in Classic Literature: A Comparative Study

In the tapestry of early modern England, where patriarchal norms dictated the lives of women, Lady Anne Clifford emerges as a figure of defiance and self-determination. Her diary, a treasure trove of personal reflections and observations, offers a captivating glimpse into the world of a woman who dared to challenge the confines of her time. Clifford, a woman of high social standing, navigated a patriarchal landscape that sought to limit her agency and control her narrative. Yet through her *Diary* and through the *Life of Me*, she was able to carve out a space for herself challenging gender roles and asserting her own voice. Throughout her writings, Clifford further raises valid questions about authorship and recognition. I argue that a close examination of Clifford's diary and the *Life of Me*, in conjunction with historical contextualization and feminist theory, reveals her as proto-feminist figure who navigated and resisted patriarchal structures through her writing. Her diary serves as a testament to her resilience and determination, unwavering in her belief in her own legitimacy. This makes Clifford to be a figure of significant historical importance both to the evolution of early modern women's writing and her potential as a source of inspiration for those who challenge societal norms, no matter the era.

Before exploring Anne Clifford's writings, it would be equally important to provide some historical context regarding the treatment of women during the early modern period, their legal rights and, how in general, authorship was viewed. The early modern period in England was a

time of rigid social hierarchies and deeply entrenched patriarchal norms. Spanning roughly from the late 15th to the late 17th century, it was a time of significant social and cultural transformation. The Renaissance and the Reformation brought new ideas and challenges to the traditional authority, yet the patriarchal structures that governed society remained deeply entrenched; with women's roles remaining largely the same. During this period, societal expectations dictated that a woman's place was in the home, her primary roles being wife, mother, and household manager. Education for women was often limited to basic literacy and religious instruction, with intellectual pursuits deemed unnecessary or even unsuitable for their gender. Women were expected to be subservient to their fathers and husbands, with limited legal rights and little control over their own lives. In this context, the act of writing, particularly for publication, was predominantly a male domain. Women who dared to write were often dismissed as lacking the intellectual capacity or the appropriate subject matter for serious authorship. Their work was often confined to private diaries or letters, with little hope of public recognition or influence.

Nonetheless, the few women who did manage to acquire an education often did so through private tutors or within the confines of their own families. The realm of authorship and literary production was particularly challenging for women in this era. Writing, especially for publication, was largely considered a male domain. Women's literary endeavors were often met with skepticism and derision, their works dismissed as frivolous or lacking the intellectual rigor associated with male authors. This bias was evident in the critical reception of women's writing, which often focused on the author's gender rather than the merits of their work. For instance, Mary Wroth was attacked and criticized, especially by Edward Denny, for her unfeminine assumption of authorship: "Work o th' works, leave idle books alone,/ For wise and worthier women have writ none." (QUOTE)

Moreso, the legal and social landscape of early modern England further reinforced women's subordinate status. Under the doctrine of coverture, a married woman's legal identity was subsumed by her husband's. She had limited rights to own property, enter into contracts, or initiate legal proceedings. Inheritance laws favored male heirs, often leaving women dependent on their fathers, husbands, or male relatives for financial support. The concept of marital rights was heavily skewed in favor of men, who held considerable authority over their wives. Divorce was rare and difficult to obtain, and domestic violence was tolerated. In this context, the act of a woman writing about her own life, expressing her own thoughts and feelings, was a radical act of defiance. It challenged the prevailing societal norms and asserted a woman's right to self-expression and intellectual autonomy.

With that being said, as a general statement or observation the societal context of Early Modern England makes Anne Clifford's literary endeavors all the more remarkable. Her extensive writings, including diaries, autobiographies, and letters, provide a unique insight into the life of a woman who defied societal expectations and actively engaged with the world around her. Her work not only documented her personal experiences but also challenged prevailing notions about women's roles and capabilities. Clifford's writings were not confined to the private sphere. She corresponded with prominent figures of her time, including statesmen, scholars, and artists. Her letters demonstrate her intellectual curiosity, her engagement with political and social issues, and her ability to navigate complex social networks. Her autobiographical writings, particularly her detailed account of her legal battles to secure her inheritance, challenged the prevailing view that women were incapable of understanding or participating in legal and financial matters. Clifford's work also provides valuable insights into the lives of other women in early modern England. Her writings document the challenges and limitations faced by women in

a patriarchal society, as well as the strategies they employed to navigate these constraints. Her letters and diaries offer glimpses into the lives of her female relatives and friends, revealing a complex network of female relationships and support systems. Understanding the historical context of women's lives in the early modern period is crucial for appreciating the significance of Anne Clifford's writings. Her work not only provides a unique window into the life of a remarkable woman but also challenges our understanding of women's roles and contributions during this period.

Now that a more general overview of women's right during the early modern era has been given and a general survey of Clifford's writing has been provided, this essay can now focus more specifically on the individual life circumstances that Anne Clifford faced, which inevitably led her to become an author. On the death of her father in 1605, Anne inherited the title of Baroness de Clifford, a title that came with a number of properties and lands. Due to Anne's sex and age however, she was denied this inheritance and instead given a sum of 15k lb. For 40 years then on, Anne would engage in a massive legal battle to secure these properties that she argued were hers by rights. The rights being engaged here followed under the principle of absolute cognitive primogeniture, in which sex is irrelevant for inheritance, the oldest surviving child, without regard to sex is the one to inherit. Legal precedence already existed, as sometime earlier King Edward II had granted the Clifford's this authority. However, it would not be until 1643, when all possible male heirs were dead, that Anne could claim her inheritance. She would not receive her properties until 1649.

However, a person might ask themselves why her inheritance was so complicated, and this can be explained, without exploring the endless nuances of the Early Modern English legal system, by looking at English marriage laws, specifically the concept of "coverture." As was

touched on earlier, under the English legal system of coverture, a woman's person was 'covered' by her husband when they married. This union was viewed as a single entity, with the husband having primary authority (NewBerry). This procedure is apparent when reading about Anne's complicated relationship to her husband, Lord Richard Sackville. A man constantly chipping away at the Clifford inheritance either through gambling or endless negotiation attempts to sell away property rights; all of course resisted by Anne.

"Upon the 17th the steward came from London and told me that my Lord was much discontented with me for not doing this business because he must be fain to tie land for the payment of the money which will much encumber his estate." (Acheson 135).

From a general reading of Clifford's memoir and diary, a modern reader can understand that she was resisting a completely unfair and sexist legal system.

"Upon the 7th presently after dinner Mr Osberton and I had a great deal of talk, he telling me how much I was condemned in the world and what strange censures most folks made of my courses, so as I kneeled down to my prayers and desired God to send a good end to these troublesome businesses, my trust being wholly in him that always helped me." (Acheson 117).

Clifford wrote her memoir and diary as a means to capture the history of her family. Till the day she died, she wrote about herself and the countless people she met. She collected genealogies, histories and personal accounts to be included in this Clifford family record. Not only did Anne effectively take charge of her family's wealth and properties but also became the primary voice and storyteller to preserve her dynastic lineage. For example, property held significant value to the Early Modern people of England, not only because land represented possible monetary gains, but it also demonstrated dynastic authority and promoted the continuous legacies of the nobility.

Anne is even more incredible in that sense that she attempts to establish her lineage through both a material and ephemeral means: through the pound and the pen.

With that being said and Clifford's history explored, it would be difficult to deny that her writings stand in stark contrast to the prevailing societal expectations of the early modern period. Clifford's writings transcend the conventional notion of a diary as a mere chronicle of daily events. Instead, it serves as a platform for Clifford to assert her individuality and challenge the limitations imposed upon her gender. Through meticulous and vivid descriptions of her daily life, Clifford paints a portrait of a woman actively engaged with the world around her. She records not only mundane and typical occurrences but also her interactions with influential figures, her travels across the country, and her involvement in legal battles to secure her rightful inheritance. These accounts showcase a woman of remarkable agency, defying the stereotype of the passive female observer.

The juxtaposition of Anne Clifford's diary and her autobiography, *The Life of Me*, offers a fascinating glimpse into the complexities of her self-representation and her evolving relationship with authorship. The diary, a private chronicle of her life, serves as an unfiltered window into her innermost thoughts and experiences. It captures the raw emotions, anxieties, and triumphs that she encountered in her daily life. The diary entries provided a candid portrayal of her marital struggles, particularly with her first husband, Richard Sackville. Clifford openly expresses her frustrations with his gambling and cockfighting addictions, his financial mismanagement, and his relentless attempts to control her inheritance. The diary reveals the emotional toll these conflicts took on her, showcasing her vulnerability and resilience in the face of adversity.

In contrast, *The Life of Me*, written in her later years, presents a more deliberate and carefully crafted narrative. Clifford, acutely aware of the work's public reception and its potential impact on her legacy, adopts a measured and formal tone. The autobiography focuses primarily on her accomplishments and her unwavering pursuit of her inheritance rights, strategically downplaying the personal struggles and emotional turmoil documented in her diary. The legal battles that dominated much of her life are recounted in detail, showcasing her knowledge of the law and her determination to prevail against patriarchal norms. While the diary reveals the raw emotions she experienced during her marital disputes, *The Life of Me* offers a more composed and matter-of-fact account emphasizing her strength and resilience rather than her vulnerability.

Central to both these works is the struggle against patriarchal control, particularly within the confines of marriage, and emerges as a recurring and poignant theme to Clifford's writing. The institution of marriage in early modern England was deeply intertwined with the transfer of property and the consolidation of power. The prevailing legal doctrine of coverture dictated that a married woman's legal identity was effectively subsumed by her husband's, severely curtailing her autonomy and rights. Women often lost control over their property and inheritance upon marriage, becoming financially dependent on their husbands. Clifford's own marital experiences were far from harmonious, marked by conflict and an extreme resistance to patriarchal dominance. For example, her first marriage to Richard Sackville, 3rd Earl of Dorset, was particularly contentious. Lord Sackville, known for his extravagant lifestyle and financial mismanagement, repeatedly attempted to usurp Clifford's inheritance rights to alleviate his debts. Clifford's diary entries from this period reveal her unwavering determination to protect her ancestral lands, even in the face of intense pressure from her husband and his creditors.

(QUOTE about protecting inheritance)... a defiant declaration of her refusal to surrender her birthright. Clifford's resistance to her first husbands' demands was not merely a matter of financial self-interest. It was a profound act of defiance against the patriarchal structures that sought to diminish her agency and control her family's destiny. Her refusal to surrender her inheritance represented a refusal to be subjugated by her husband and a strong assertion of her own identity and autonomy. In a society that often-viewed women as mere appendages to their husbands, Clifford's unyielding determination to protect her lands was a radical act of self-preservation and a testament to her indomitable spirit.

The challenges to Anne Clifford's autonomy did not cease with her first marriage and her second marriage to Philip Herbert, 4th Earl of Pembroke and 1st Earl of Montgomery was similarly fraught with issues. The pervasive patriarchal structures of the time continued to cast a shadow over her life, as Herbert, like her first husband, sought to exert control over her vast inheritance. The prevailing societal norms and legal framework of early modern England granted husbands this authority over their wives, leaving women vulnerable to exploitation for lands and other rights. However, Clifford's resilience and determination to protect her rights remained undiminished. Her diary entries from this period offer a compelling narrative to her refusal to be cowed by her husband's authority, an experience she had already suffered. She actively resisted any attempts to encroach upon her inheritance, documenting her efforts to assert her rights and maintain control over her estates. The diary reveals a woman who was not content to be a passive observer in her own life but actively engaged in managing her affairs and defending her autonomy. For example, Clifford documents her efforts to assert her rights, including her travels to her various estates and her active involvement in their management. She further writes of visiting her castles, inspecting lands, and interacting with her tenants, demonstrating her active

involvement in the management of her inheritance. (Quote about visiting a property.)... a clear assertion of her ownership and authority. Clifford's writings thus become a powerful tool of resistance against the patriarchal structures that sought to constrain her. Through her writing, she reclaims her agency, documenting her struggles and triumphs in a society that often sought to silence women's voices. Her words serve as a testament to her courage and resilience and can act as inspiration for generations of women to challenge societal norms and fight for their rights. Beyond its function as a personal record, Clifford's diary emerges as a potent tool of resistance against the patriarchal forces that sought to constrain her. Through her writing, she reclaims her agency, documenting her struggles and triumphs in a society that often demanded that women be silent. Her words offer a powerful counter-narrative to the prevailing patriarchal discourse that confined women to a limited domestic sphere, dictated their private spaces and denied them control over their lives. The diary and *The Life of Me* become more than just a chronicle of events; it is a political act to affirm feminine autonomy.

However, the diary and *The Life of Me* include some considerable and key differences. For one, in the intended audience and purpose of the works. The diary was primarily a private document, serving as a personal outlet for Clifford to process her experiences and emotions. This private nature allows for a level of candor and vulnerability that is absent from her more public-facing autobiography. For instance, Clifford's diary entries often contain intimate details about her relationships, health concerns, spiritual reflections, offering a glimpse into the complexities of her inner life. As such, the diary is arguably unburdened by the constraints of public scrutiny and societal expectations. In contrast, *The Life of Me* was consciously crafted with a broader audience in mind, serving as both a personal testament and a carefully constructed public image. Clifford's awareness of this broader readership is evident in the work's focus on her

accomplishments, her resilience in the face of adversity, and her unwavering commitment to justice and her inheritance rights. The autobiography strategically omits the more personal and vulnerable aspects of her life, presenting a narrative that emphasizes her strength and determination. Ultimately, I would argue that this is a deliberate performance on Clifford's part, aimed at securing her legacy and inspiring future generations. Overall, the diary's private nature allowed Anne to explore her innermost thoughts and feelings, while *The Life of Me*, written with a public audience mind, served as a platform for self-fashioning and legacy building. The contrast between these two works highlights Clifford's understanding of the power of narrative and her ability to adapt her writing to different contexts and purposes.

Another key difference between the works is found in their chosen language and style. The diary is written in a colloquial and conversational style, reflecting Clifford's everyday speech patterns. (QUOTE WITH EXAMPLE). It is rich in detail, capturing the nuances of her interactions with others in the Royal court and the minutiae of daily life. Contrastingly, *The Life of Me* employs a more formal and elevated language, befitting its autobiographical genre and intended audience. It is less concerned with the minutiae of daily life and more focused on presenting a coherent and compelling narrative of Clifford's life. (QUOTE WITH EXAMPLE). The stylistic differences between the two works also extend to their structural organization. The diary, written in chronological order, unfolds as a series of episodic entries, reflecting the ebb and flow of Clifford's life. On the other hand, *The Life of Me* follows a more linear and thematic structure, carefully arranging events to create a cohesive narrative arc. This deliberate organization or rather structure serves to highlight Clifford's agency and resilience, presenting her life as a purposeful journey towards self-actualization and the reclamation of her rightful inheritance. While these differences are significant, both the diary and *The Life of Me* ultimately

serve to illuminate Clifford's remarkable character. The differences between these two works underscore Clifford's astute awareness of audience and purpose. The diary/memoir served as a private outlet for reflection and emotional release, while the *The Life of Me* was intended for a wider readership, serving as both a personal testament and a political statement. Both works, however, demonstrate Clifford's determination to control her own narrative, defying societal expectations and asserting her agency in a world that sought to silence women's voices.

Another notable feature of Clifford's writing, though more so her character, was her status as a woman of the elite class. The complexities of Anne Clifford's social standing as a woman of the elite class in early modern England add a unique dimension to her diary and autobiography. While her elevated position granted her certain privileges and opportunities inaccessible to most women of her time, it also subjected her to intense scrutiny and attempts at control, particularly concerning her vast inheritance. The interplay between her social status and gender roles is evident in both her diary and *The Life of Me*, revealing her navigation of societal expectations, her subtle challenges to norms, and her advocacy for her rights. The advantages of Clifford's elevated social status are readily apparent in her writings. The refined eloquence of her prose and her comprehensive grasp of legal and political intricacies underscore the educational opportunities that her position afforded her. Such intellectual pursuits were a rarity for women in the early modern era, highlighting the unique privileges that accompanied Clifford's social standing. The diary serves as a testament to her engagement with the intellectual currents of her time, showcasing a woman who defied societal expectations by actively participating in the world of ideas. For example, Clifford's diary entries frequently feature detailed accounts of her interactions with the most influential figures of the Jacobean court. These encounters, ranging from casual conversations to formal events, illustrate

her deep social connections and her ability to navigate the intricate protocols of courtly life. She writes with familiarity about attending Queen Anne's masque, a lavish spectacle of courtly entertainment, and dining with King James himself. These experiences not only underscore her proximity to power but also her active participation in the social and cultural life of the elite. Clifford's diary thus offers a rare glimpse into the world of the early modern court from a female perspective, revealing the opportunities and challenges that accompanied her elevated social status.

However, Clifford's elevated social status, while affording her certain privileges, also made her a prime target for those who coveted her wealth and influence. Her personal writings, including her diary, provide a glimpse into the relentless pressure she endured from husbands, family members, and even the monarchy to surrender her inheritance rights. These legal battles she waged to safeguard her lands were not merely a testament to her tenacity but also a stark reflection of the distinct challenges she faced as a woman of considerable social standing in that era. The patriarchal norms of the time dictated that women were often expected to defer to their male relatives in matters of inheritance and property. Clifford's refusal to comply with these expectations, as evidenced in her written accounts, underscores her defiance of societal norms and her unwavering commitment to preserving her own agency. In doing so, Clifford not only protected her own interests but also challenged the societal norms that sought to limit the power and agency of women. Her legacy serves as an inspiration to others who may find themselves facing similar challenges.

Clifford's writing, particularly her diary, also reveals her subtle challenges to societal norms. While she adhered to many of the conventions expected of a woman of her class, she also pushed boundaries in subtle ways. Her meticulous accounts of her travels and active involvement

in managing her vast estates stand in stark contrast to the prevailing image of the passive and domesticated noblewoman of her time. In an era when women were largely expected to confine their interests to domestic affairs, Clifford's active participation in traditionally male domains was a quiet but powerful act of defiance. In "The Life of Me," she proudly recounts her restoration of her family's castles, a traditionally male domain, further asserting her agency and challenging gender roles. Clifford's writings reveal a complex and multifaceted woman who skillfully navigated the societal expectations of her time while carving out a space for her own ambitions and desires. She was not merely a passive observer but an active participant in her own life, determined to make her mark on the world. In her quiet defiance, Clifford serves as an inspiration to those who challenge societal norms and expectations. Her story reminds us that even within the constraints of tradition, there is always room for agency, resilience, and the pursuit of one's passions.

Furthermore, Lady Anne Clifford's position within the upper echelons of society afforded her a unique platform, positioning her as a potential role model for other women during the 17th century. Her writings, particularly her autobiography "The Life of Me," served as a beacon of female agency and resilience in a society dominated by patriarchal norms. In an era where women's voices were often silenced or marginalized, Clifford's candid documentation of her personal struggles and triumphs was a revolutionary act. She openly chronicled her battles for inheritance rights, her challenges in navigating complex legal systems, and her unwavering determination to maintain control over her own destiny. By doing so, she demonstrated the potential for women to challenge societal norms and assert their rights, even within the confines of their social class. Through her writings, Clifford provided a roadmap for women to navigate the complexities of a patriarchal society. She showed that even within the constraints of societal

norms, women could find ways to exercise agency, assert their rights, and make their voices heard. Her story served as a source of inspiration and empowerment, encouraging women to challenge the status quo and strive for a more equitable society. In the end, Clifford's legacy as a role model extends far beyond her own lifetime. Her writings continue to resonate with readers today, reminding us of the power of female resilience and the importance of challenging societal norms that limit women's potential. Her story serves as a testament to the enduring power of the written word to inspire, empower, and effect change.

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Commented [A1]: focuses on the Sidney family: i.e. not really relevant to Clifford. Perhaps there will be something useful to draw on for a discussion of gender and authorship in the introduction

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